

Introduction

“Reality is merely an illusion, albeit a very persistent one.”

– Albert Einstein

Given that exquisite premise by Mr. Einstein, consider this for a moment: what would happen if you add to that illusion? Would the result be more illusory or more real? Before our minds implode under the weight of the conundrum, let's get down to what we want to talk about – Augmented Reality.

Augmented reality (AR) is the altering your perception of the world by wrapping a layer around reality. A layer of augmentation. They say reality is a hard pill to swallow. So how about reality served with a sugar coating of information? Augmented Reality can help in multiple ways – provide critical information about your surroundings, give you your personal babel fish, help soldiers survive wars better, help law enforcement officials catch criminals, avoid car accidents, train surgeons, and much more. But AR is not just about this, it can be fun too! Yep it has limitless possibilities in gaming

This FastTrack will take you into the world of Augmented Reality on a magic carpet ride of sorts. We first begin by introducing you to the key concepts and also differentiate AR from another closely related concept – Virtual Reality. Next we tell you about the earliest attempts at augmentation in the form of Experience Theaters to newer milestones like Google Glasses. We also try to chronicle some of the pivotal moments in this space.

The most notable (and famous) implementation of AR, as of now, are the location browsers running on mobiles that help you locate points of interest around you. As you read this FastTrack, you'll be surprised to learn that (metaphorically) AR is much larger than what a mobile phone can accommodate. You would learn its various uses and types.

We do not stop there and we don't want you to either. We explore the significance of AR and how it is set to change the world as we see it. We show